

TIOBE Index March 2026

Programming Language Popularity Rankings and Trends

How 20+ Search Engines Rank the World's Programming Languages

Presented to: Software Engineering Leads & Technology Strategists

Source: TIOBE Programming Community Index | tiobe.com | Captured April 10, 2026

Python Holds #1 at 21.25% but C Surges to #2 with the Largest Gain

Top 20 Programming Languages — March 2026

Rank	Prev	Language	Rating	YoY Chg
1	1	Python	21.25%	-2.59%
2	4	C	11.55%	+2.02%
3	2	C++	8.18%	-2.90%
4	3	Java	7.99%	-2.37%
5	5	C#	6.36%	+1.49%
6	6	JavaScript	3.45%	-0.01%
7	9	Visual Basic	2.50%	-0.02%
8	8	SQL	2.00%	-0.57%
9	16	R	1.88%	+0.94%
10	10	Delphi/Object Pascal	1.80%	-0.36%
11	24	Perl	1.75%	+1.05%
12	12	Scratch	1.63%	-0.03%
13	11	Fortran	1.45%	-0.25%
14	14	Rust	1.31%	+0.09%
15	15	MATLAB	1.29%	+0.31%
16	7	Go	1.29%	-1.49%
17	17	Assembly language	1.29%	+0.42%
18	13	PHP	1.23%	-0.25%
19	18	Ada	1.10%	+0.25%
20	26	Swift	1.04%	+0.44%

KEY INSIGHTS

- Python leads at 21.25% — more than double C's 11.55%
- C jumped from #4 to #2 with +2.02% YoY — largest gain among top 5
- C++ dropped from #2 to #3 despite gaining +2.02% rating points last year
- Top 4 languages hold 48.97% of total index — extreme concentration
- Python's -2.59% YoY is the largest decline among the top 5
- Go fell from #7 to #16, losing 1.49 pp — worst absolute drop in top 20

Perl Jumps 13 Spots, R Climbs 7, and Go Drops 9 — The Biggest Rank Shifts of 2026

RISING

Perl	+13	24th → 11th	+1.05%	Revival in automation & DevOps scripting
R	+7	16th → 9th	+0.94%	Growth in data science & statistical computing
Swift	+6	26th → 20th	+0.44%	Apple ecosystem momentum in mobile
C#	+0	5th → 5th	+1.49%	.NET ecosystem steady growth
Rust	+0	14th → 14th	+0.09%	Systems programming interest rising
Assembly	+0	17th → 17th	+0.42%	Low-level / embedded demand

FALLING

Go	-9	7th → 16th	-1.49%	Largest drop; possible Rust displacement
C++	-1	2nd → 3rd	-2.90%	Slipped past C in year-over-year rating
Java	-1	3rd → 4th	-2.37%	Continuing long-term decline from peak
PHP	-5	13th → 18th	-0.25%	Web-backend share steadily eroding
SQL	-1	8th → 10th	-0.57%	Slight pullback from 2025 levels

From Lisp at #2 in 1986 to Python at #1 in 2026: How Language Rankings Shifted Over Time

Language	2026	2021	2016	2011	2006	2001	1996
Python	1	3	5	7	8	26	17
C	2	1	2	2	2	1	1
C++	3	4	3	3	3	2	2
Java	4	2	1	1	1	3	31
C#	5	5	4	5	7	11	-
JavaScript	6	7	8	10	10	8	33
Go	10	11	60	16	-	-	-
Ada	14	36	25	22	16	18	6
Lisp	26	34	26	13	14	19	8

KEY PATTERNS

Python's Meteoric Rise

Unranked in 1991 → top 30 by 2001 → #1 by 2026 after 18 years at the top. Peak above 25% in 2024.

C: The Indomitable Constant

Only language in the top 2 across all 9 measurement points from 1986 to 2026. #1 as recently as 2021.

Java's Long Decline

Dominated from ~2005–2018 at 25%+ → fell to #4 by 2026. Sustained multi-decade downtrend.

Lisp's Free Fall

#2 in 1986 → #26 by 2026. Classic AI language that failed to maintain relevance.

Ada's Slow Descent

Peaked at #3 in 1986 → #14 by 2026. Once for defense/avionics, now a niche legacy language.

Go's Rollercoaster

Entered at #60 in 2016 → reached #7 in 2021 → dropped to #16 by 2026. Rapid rise, sharp fall.

Python Wins Language of the Year 6 Times — More Than Any Other Language

Programming Language of the Year Winners (2016–2025)



Python: 6 Wins

2007 • 2010 • 2018 • 2020 • 2021 • 2024

C#: 2 Wins (2023, 2025)

Go: 1 Win (2016) — followed by its steepest decline

2017 winner data not available in source brief.

Note: The TIOBE Language of the Year award recognizes the language with the largest gain in ratings during a calendar year.

The Top 4 Languages Hold 49% of the Index: What This Means for Your Tech Stack

Python Dominant but Declining

21.25% share makes Python the safe choice for hiring & tooling, but its -2.59% YoY is the largest drop among the top 5. Evaluate whether AI/ML growth will reverse this trend before over-investing.

Go's Fall Is a Warning Sign

Go fell from #7 to #16 — the steepest drop in the top 20 — despite its 2016 Language of the Year win. Rust's parallel rise (+0.09 pp) suggests displacement in systems programming.

C's Resurgence — A Systems Programming Revival?

C surged to #2 (+2.02 pp) — its highest rank since 2001. With Rust rising in parallel, low-level systems programming is undergoing a renaissance. C remains critical for embedded, OS, and IoT work.

Top-4 Concentration = Concentration Risk

Python + C + C++ + Java = 48.97% of the index. Betting on only 2–3 languages creates hiring bottlenecks and vendor lock-in. Diversify tooling strategy across language families.

Legacy Languages Are Not Dead

Perl (+13 ranks), R (+7), Fortran (+holding #13), and Assembly (+0.42 pp) show that entrenched communities sustain languages decades after their peaks. Do not discount legacy for new.

Swift Re-Enters, Kotlin Exits — Mobile Shifts

Swift climbed 26th → 20th; Kotlin dropped to 22nd. Apple-platform momentum and cross-platform framework competition are actively reshaping the mobile language landscape.